"What Documents Would We Need?" and Other Questions Families Ask About Preparing Ahead for a Medicaid Application

Plain answers to general questions, and when to take yours to a professional.

Families who start thinking ahead about a Medicaid application tend to wonder the same things. These are the questions that come up most, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Dad in particular, and none states the rule for his state. Where a question needs someone who knows his situation, the answer says who to ask.

1 Nobody is applying for anything. Why think about an application at all?

Because the records are easier to find when there is time and Dad can tell you where he keeps things. Medicaid comes into conversations about long-term care because Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term care in a nursing home, and Medicaid is the joint federal and state program that helps pay health care costs for people with limited income and, in some cases, resources, who meet other requirements. Keeping records isn't a decision to apply. It's a file that is there if your family ever needs it. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know whether Medicaid is likely to come into Dad's picture at all. That depends on his situation and his state.

2 What documents would we need?

It depends on the state, and USA.gov says so directly. In general, a state Medicaid agency may ask for things such as a name and date of birth, a Social Security number, proof of citizenship or immigration status, proof of income and information about current insurance. The federal Administration for Community Living adds that an applicant will have to provide documentation of what assets they have. So the kinds of records are identity, income, accounts, insurance and property. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want the actual list for Dad's state. Your Medicaid planner explains which records an application-ready file should hold, and the state Medicaid agency can say what it requires.

3 How far back do the records need to go?

This guide can't give you a number. It depends on the state and the situation, and program requirements can change over time. What the Administration for Community Living does say is that if a person's assets went down a lot in the years before applying, the state may ask what happened to them. Until you've asked, keep the statements that arrive and hold on to the ones Dad already has. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're sorting out what to keep. Ask your Medicaid planner how far back records should go in Dad's state.

4 Where would an application even go?

To the state. States run Medicaid day to day, including taking applications and deciding eligibility, and Medicaid.gov tells people to contact their state Medicaid agency to apply. Program names can vary from state to state, so the program in Dad's state may be called something else. [4] [6] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know which office and which program would apply to Dad. Your Medicaid planner or the state Medicaid agency can tell you.

5 Who fills it out? Does it have to be Dad?

Not necessarily. The Administration for Community Living says a person may apply themselves or designate someone else, such as a family member, an attorney or a friend. Whoever applies for another person should be familiar with the situation, be able to answer the eligibility questions and have access to the financial records. That's a good reason to ask Dad who he'd want, and to make sure that person knows where the file is. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** nobody is sure who it would be, or how that person would get to Dad's records. Your Medicaid planner reviews who would be responsible for an eventual application; questions about legal authority go to an elder law attorney.

6 How would we make sure an application is filled out correctly?

For now, nobody is filling one out. What a family can do ahead of time is keep the records the answers would come from, so that whoever completes a form later is working from statements and not from memory. When there is an application, it is prepared with an applications specialist. Elder law attorneys are another kind of professional who, the Administration for Community Living says, explore a person's qualifications for Medicaid and, if appropriate, apply on their behalf. [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** an application is actually in view. That is when your Medicaid planner reviews readiness with the family and an applications specialist comes in.

7 What happens after an application is sent in?

In general terms, the state reviews it, and the documents matter: the Administration for Community Living says it may take longer for the state to determine eligibility if required documents aren't provided on time. The decision comes by letter. An approval letter gives the date of eligibility and the amount the person must pay toward the cost of care; a denial letter explains the reason and how to appeal. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know how long any of it takes, or what a letter would mean for Dad. That depends on the state and the case, and it's a question for your Medicaid planner or an applications specialist when the time comes.

8 Dad sold the truck and helped a grandchild with tuition. Do we need to do anything about that?

Write it down: what happened, roughly when, and what paperwork exists. The Administration for Community Living says a state may ask an applicant to explain what happened to assets whose value went down a lot in the years before applying, and a dated note made while people remember is easier than piecing it together later. Whether an event matters for an application at all depends on the state and the situation. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what a gift, a sale or a transfer means for Medicaid, or someone is thinking about making one. That's for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney. This guide can't judge it.

9 When would it be time to actually apply?

That's a question to bring to a professional, not one to settle at home. The Administration for Community Living says the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances. What a family can do ahead of time is write the question down and work out with your Medicaid planner the circumstances that would tell you it's time. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something changes in Dad's health, his living situation or his finances and you wonder whether it changes the answer.

10 How do we keep the file from going stale?

Give it a keeper and a date. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says to keep information as current as possible when something changes, such as a new account, and the National Institute on Aging suggests reviewing plans regularly and when a major life event occurs. Write the date of the last update at the top of the file, with the name of whoever keeps it. [9] [10]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something big has changed, such as a move, a sale or a change in Dad's health, and you're not sure what to add. Your Medicaid planner reviews the family's record-keeping system.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Dad's own situation, state a limit, a time period or a deadline, or say whether or when to apply. Rules vary by state and change. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions, and a sense of which ones belong to a professional. The planning interview is where the questions become about your family: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
2. USA.gov, How to apply for Medicaid and CHIP
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
5. National Institute on Aging, Paying for Long-Term Care
6. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicaid.gov), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?

7. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication), Medicaid: Getting Started
8. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?
9. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
10. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future

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